

Lord Krishna gave his sister a detailed narrative on how a chakravyuh could be penetrated and successfully traversed to its core. He was about to explain how one could safely exit the spiral when he noticed his sister, bored with the tale, had fallen asleep. Krishna, finding himself without an audience, left the story unfinished. But there was an interested listener present. From his mother's womb, the unborn Abhimanyu had been keenly absorbing the discourse.

Abhimanyu's father, Arjuna, was the greatest archer in the world. Following in his father's footsteps, even at the tender age of 16, Abhimanyu was an accomplished warrior. Finding his side sustaining deep losses, he offered to penetrate the chakravyuh—even though he did not know how he would exit once he got to its center. Under pressure, the Pandava leadership reluctantly agreed to let him proceed—planning to follow closely behind to keep him out of trouble.

Remembering Lord Krishna's technique, Abhimanyu successfully entered the chakravyuh and swiftly advanced toward its center—slaying scores of Kaurava troops who tried to stop him. However, the Kauravas were successful at sealing off the chakravyuh right after Abhimanyu's entry, so no additional Pandavas could follow Abhimanyu's lead. At the center, nine of the best Kaurava warriors battled Abhimanyu simultaneously. Not knowing how to break out of the chakravyuh, Abhimanyu stayed put at the center and put up a brave fight with all nine. In the end, he succumbed to his injuries and died.

Abhimanyu's dilemma on that 13th day of battle has close parallels to the decisions confronting equity investors every day. The decision to enter, traverse, and finally exit a chakravyuh is akin to figuring out when to buy, hold, and sell a given stock. The lesson Abhimanyu has for us is to have a crystal-clear exit plan before we ever think about buying a stock.

TO ENTER OR NOT TO ENTER—THAT IS THE QUESTION